

Acquisition Read — Nestor Cortes (LHP)

Signed by the Phillies 2026-08-19 · 1-yr prorated major-league deal · returning from arm surgery · the pre-return baseline

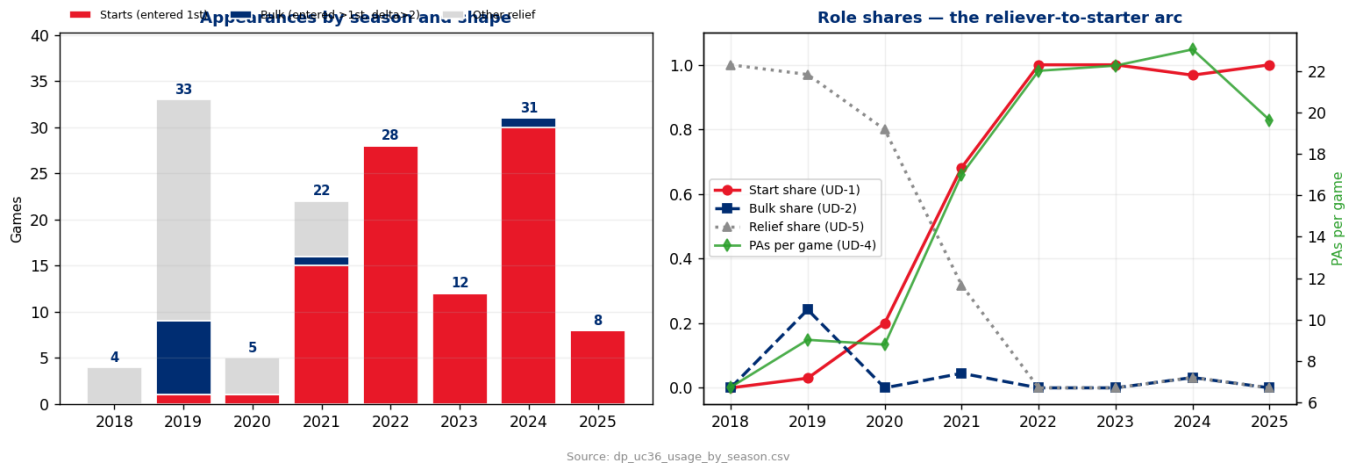
Prepared for: manager / battery / pitching department — onboarding dossier, not an opponent attack plan **Throws:** L · **Arsenal (2023-25):** 4-Seam, Cutter, Sweeper, Changeup (+ trace Sinker/Slider) **Governance:** Use Case #37 (uc-pps-026) · build dp_uc36 · KPIs inherited verbatim from the dp_uc29/dp_uc30 acquisition chain · NEW: UD deployment family (UD-1..6, DPO-supplied definitions) · third acquisition-onboarding read, first that is also a return-from-surgery read

Read this first — data window & sample sizes. - Source: data/opponents/cortes.parquet, entity lock pitcher == 641482, career 2018-03-31 → 2025-09-03, regular-season rates only. Postseason (incl. the 2024 World Series) is context, never blended. - **He has thrown zero competitive pitches since 2025-09-03.** Arm surgery mid-Oct 2025 (type not publicly specified — not guessed here). **2026 is a true gap.** Everything below is a baseline to measure his return against, and says so wherever it matters. - 2025 is 8 games / 157 PA and was already injury-interrupted (MIL 2 starts Mar–Apr → four-month gap → SD 6 starts Aug–Sep). **Every 2025 number prints its PA.** - 2023 is a 12-start injury season (266 PA). His last sustained relief work is 2019–21 — leverage evidence is eradicated and flagged as such. - Manual carry-ins: signing date/terms, **Brian Keller DFA'd for the 40-man spot (DPO correction to the intake doc)**, surgery timing, 2022 All-Star selection, reported expectation of a multi-inning role.

Bottom line

1. **He has done every job the Phillies might ask — and the bulk job specifically.** 2019: 33 appearances, 24.2% bulk share (8 bulk outings by the DPO's definition) plus long relief. 2021: live conversion year (15 starts of 22 games). 2022 on: a starter, full stop (78 of 79 appearances were starts, 2022–25). The six-man-rotation / bulk conversation is not a projection — it's his résumé.
2. **The lefty edge is real and it survived the decline.** Career vs LHB .301 wOBA (533 PA) vs RHB .309 (1,961 PA) looks neutral — but since 2022 it isn't: **.161 wOBA vs LHB in 2022 (89 PA, 37.1% K)** and **.233 vs LHB across 2023-24 (198 PA)** while RHB did the damage (.329, 780 PA). The decline was a right-handed-batter problem, not a lefty one.
3. **What decayed from the 2022 peak was contact management and the first pitch, not the swing-and-miss.** 2022 → 2023-24: hard-hit% **+8.3 pts** (34.7 → 43.0), xwOBAcon .321 → .360, first-pitch-strike% **-6.5 pts** (67.2 → 60.7), chase -3.8 pts. Whiff (24.5 → 24.2) and zone rate (51.4 → 50.9 strict) barely moved. The stuff still missed bats; the misses over the plate got punished harder, and he stopped winning pitch one.
4. **The number to watch on his return is 92, not 19.** His four-seam ride is stable (IVB ~19.3 in every year since 2022). His velocity is not: 92.1 mph across 2024 (climbing to 92.7 by September), then **90.1 in the injury-broken 2025** — a two-mph drop that predates the surgery. If the rebuilt arm gives back 91.5+, the 2022-24 profile is live; at 90, the 2025 damage profile (.440 xwOBAcon, 46.2% hard-hit, 157 PA) is the honest prior.
5. **So what:** deploy him as a **multi-inning/bulk lefty on a two-pass leash (≈18 BF)** while the velocity answers the question, spot him at left-handed stretches on merit, and treat a one-run ninth as earned later, not assumed now. The specific persona plans are below.

Nestor Cortes — how he has been deployed (UD family, DPO definitions)



How he has been deployed — the UD family (Business Question 1)

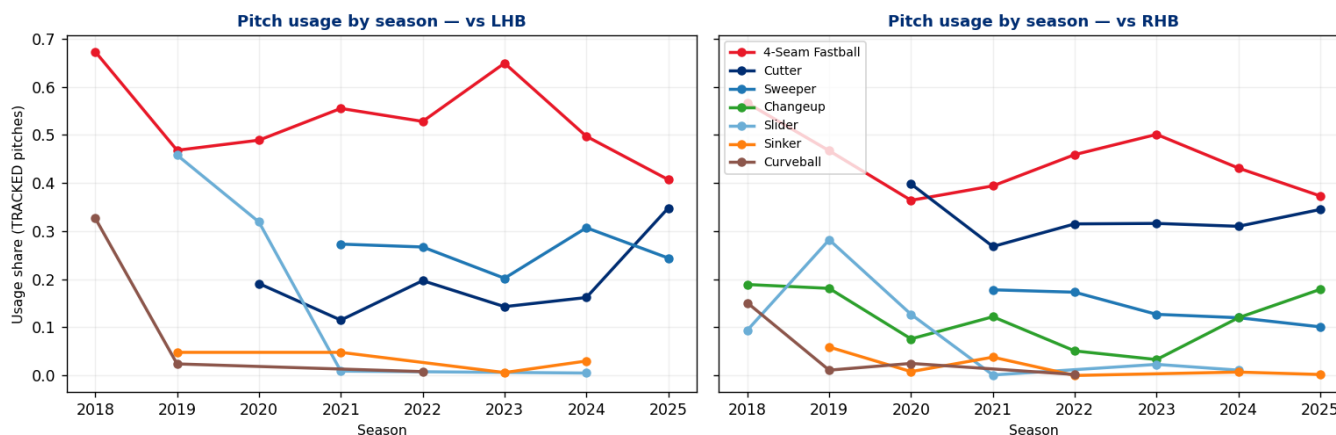
Season	G	Starts	Bulks	Start share	Bulk share	Relief share	IP/gm (delta)	PA/gm	Role label
2018 (BAL)	4	0	0	.000	.000	1.000	0.50	6.8	relief-heavy
2019 (NYY)	33	1	8	.030	.242	.970	1.45	9.0	bulk/hybrid
2020 (SEA)	5	1	0	.200	.000	.800	0.80	8.8	relief-heavy
2021 (NYY)	22	15	1	.682	.045	.318	3.50	17.0	bulk/hybrid
2022 (NYY)	28	28	0	1.000	.000	.000	5.04	22.0	start-heavy
2023 (NYY)	12	12	0	1.000	.000	.000	4.83	22.3	start-heavy
2024 (NYY)	31	30	1	.968	.032	.032	4.94	23.0	start-heavy
2025 (MIL → SD)	8	8	0	1.000	.000	.000	3.75	19.6	start-heavy

IP/gm is the DPO's delta definition (exit inning – entry inning); innings-appeared ships alongside in the receipt. The DPO's notebook classification reproduces exactly — this table is that analysis, kernel-computed and receipted.

The arc the use case hypothesized is confirmed and sharpened: reliever with real bulk work (2019) → transition (2021) → pure starter (2022-25). Two details matter for 2026. First, his 2019 bulk outings were genuine multi-inning stints behind another pitcher — the exact shape the reporting expects him to fill now. Second, **his 2025 starts averaged only 75 pitches (range 57–90)** — even before surgery he was being run at bulk length, not workhorse length.

What he throws, and to whom (Business Question 2)

Arsenal evolution by batter hand



Source: dp_uc36_mix_by_hand_season.csv

vs LHB (2023-25, 877 tracked pitches): three pitches — four-seam 51.2%, sweeper 27.7%, cutter 18.7% — and **68.5% of everything lives glove-side (away)**, exactly the pattern the DPO's own figure flagged. The sweeper is the weapon: .247 xwOBACon, 35.1% whiff. The four-seam is the current problem: **.457 xwOBACon, 61.4% hard-hit, 7 of the 10 HR he has allowed to LHB since 2023** — when a LHB gets the heater, he hasn't missed it lately.

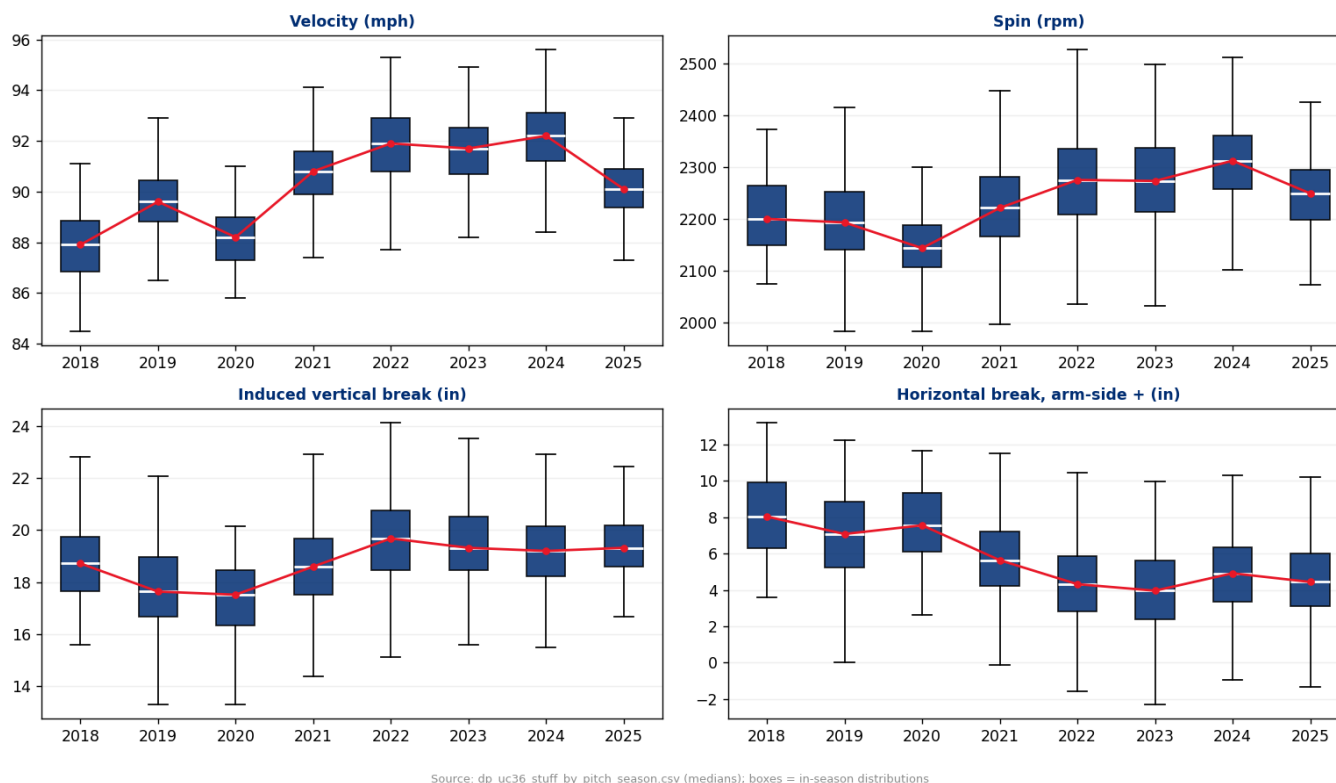
vs RHB (2023-25, 3,639 tracked pitches): a four-pitch look — four-seam 44.1%, cutter 31.6%, changeup 10.6% (arm-side away, mean plate_x +0.87), sweeper 12.0%. Two-strike RHB see changeup 15.1% (32.7% whiff — his best RHB putaway) and four-seam 47.7%. When behind vs RHB he leans cutter (44.8%) — a scoutable tell. The sweeper vs RHB is his riskiest offering (.409 xwOBACon).

Split	PA	wOBA	K%	Whiff%	Hard-hit%	xwOBACon
2022 peak vs LHB	89	.161	37.1%	33.0%	32.7%	.309
2022 peak vs RHB	527	.259	24.7%	23.1%	35.0%	.323
2023-24 vs LHB	198	.233	28.3%	29.4%	38.2%	.320
2023-24 vs RHB	780	.329	22.2%	23.0%	44.2%	.369
2025 vs LHB	39	.547	20.5%	21.0%	71.4%	.678
2025 vs RHB	118	.357	17.8%	26.3%	37.2%	.355

The 2025 vs-LHB line is ugly and it is **39 PA in an injury-broken season — directional only, don't over-read it**. The 287-PA post-peak lefty record (2023-24) is the better evidence, and it says the platoon edge held.

The stuff, and what was trending before the injury (Business Question 3)

Tracking the stuff — four-seam fastball (FF), by season



FF by season	Pitches	Velo	Spin	IVB (in)	HB (in)	Whiff%	xwOBACon
2019	607	89.6	2189	17.8	6.9	26.5%	.461
2021	653	90.7	2223	18.6	5.6	23.1%	.370
2022	1,155	91.8	2270	19.5	4.5	25.8%	.324
2023	560	91.6	2273	19.4	4.1	25.1%	.314
2024	1,266	92.1	2309	19.2	4.9	21.5%	.378
2025	228	90.1	2248	19.3	4.5	19.4%	.513

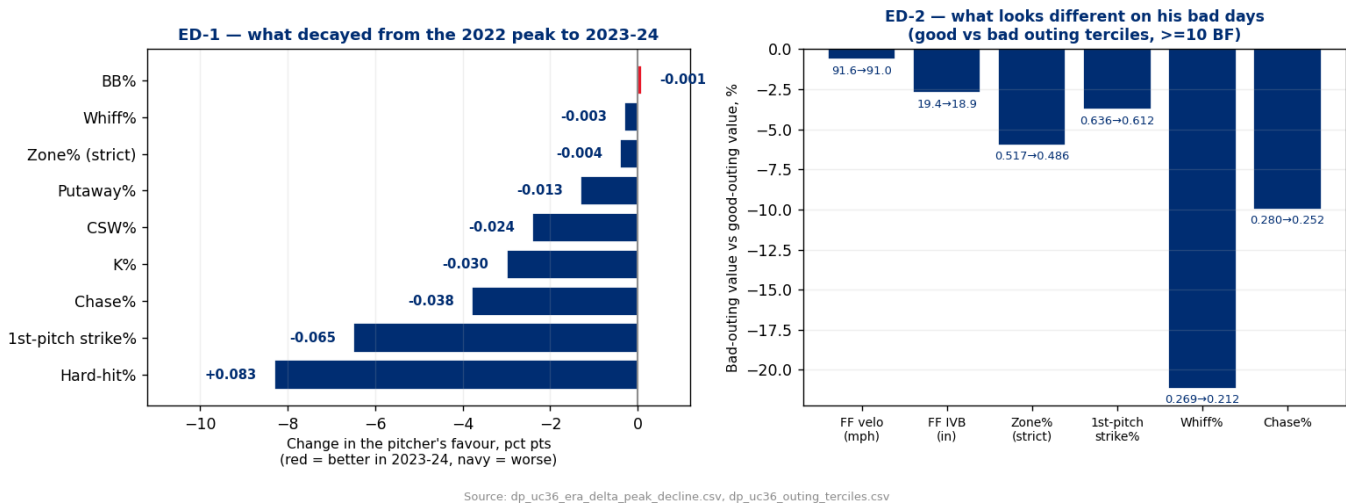
Three reads, in order of importance:

- 1. Velocity is the injury tell and the return cue.** The DPO's intake said "he is slowing down but not particularly fast" — half right. He was actually *gaining* velo through 2024 (monthly receipt: 91.5 in April 2024 → 92.7 in September 2024). Then 2025 opened at 90.6 (MIL), and the post-layoff SD stint sat 90.1 with his final start at 89.5. **The two-mph gap between late-2024 and 2025 is the single most important number in this product.**
- 2. The ride is his identity and it never wavered.** IVB has been 19.2–19.5 since 2022 — flat through the decline and flat through the injury year at ~19.3. Shape survived; the engine didn't. That is the optimistic read for a surgical return: the pitch design needs no rebuild.
- 3. The mechanical drift is real and worth a baseline.** Arm angle has climbed steadily (45.1° in 2022 → 48.7° 2023 → 51.2° 2025) and his release point has moved ~0.9 ft toward the center line (release_pos_x 1.97 → 1.11) and ~0.4 ft higher since 2019.

None of this is flagged as a defect — Cortes famously manipulates slots — but the department should photograph his post-surgery slot against this receipt (`dp_uc36_mechanics_by_season.csv`) in his first bullpen.

What drives his good and bad stretches (Business Question 4)

Performance drivers — era decay and outing-level tells



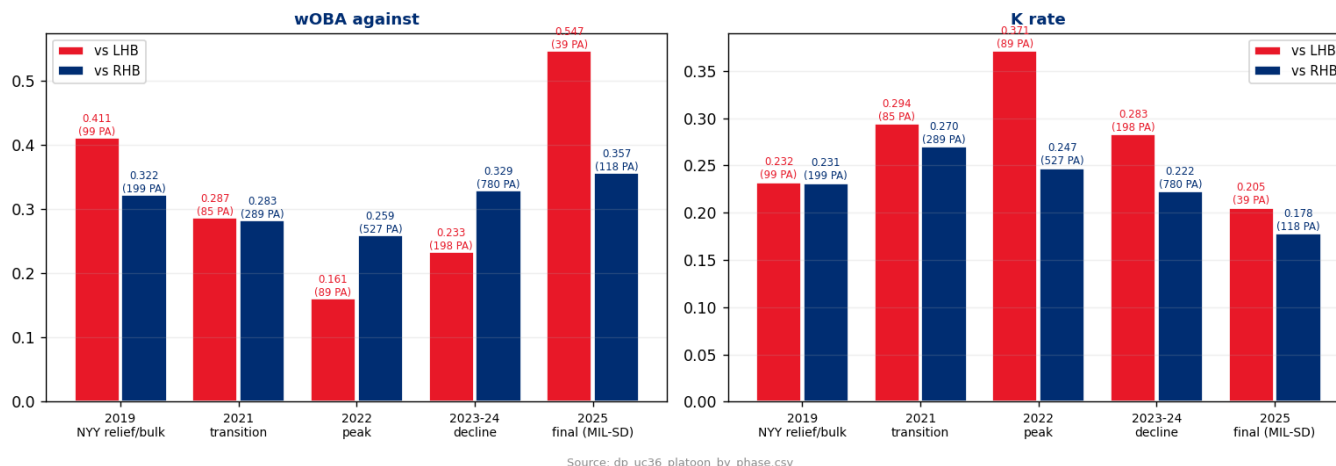
Era level (2022 peak → 2023-24, 616 vs 978 PA): the decline signature is hard-hit% +8.3 pts, xwOBAcon +.039, first-pitch-strike% −6.5 pts, chase% −3.8 pts, K% −3.0 pts — while whiff, zone rate and BB% held. He didn't lose the ability to miss bats; he lost the ability to *manage the contact he allowed* and stopped stealing pitch one.

Outing level (114 career outings ≥10 BF, terciled by wOBA-against): his bad days carry a legible signature — whiff .269 → .212 (−21% relative), zone-strict .517 → .486, FF velo 91.6 → 91.0, chase .280 → .252, hard-hit .355 → .426. **The in-game tell is whiffs and zone, not radar-gun collapse** — velo moves only ~0.6 mph between his best and worst days, but the swing-and-miss evaporates.

Season co-movement (receipt `dp_uc36_season_indicators.csv`): across his eight seasons, wOBA-against tracks hard-hit%/xwOBAcon and FPSR far more tightly than it tracks velo or whiff — consistent with both reads above. Eight seasons is eight data points; this is ranked co-movement, not inference.

Platoon summary figure

Platoon splits by career phase (PA printed on every bar)



The persona plans

Manager — deployment

- Bulk/multi-inning first, rotation later.** His 2019 season is a proven template (8 bulk outings), his 2025 starts were already ~75-pitch outings, and there is no 2026 game data to justify more. A six-man-rotation slot is the *destination* if velocity returns; the stretch-run role is 2-4 innings behind a starter or opener.
- Two passes, then get him.** Career TTO: .280 wOBA first time through (855 PA) → .305 second (814) → .334 third-plus (400). Velocity holds through the order (91.6/91.5/91.6) — the fade is familiarity, not fatigue. An 18-BF leash captures his best.
- High-leverage lefty innings: earn, don't assume.** The platoon case is real (bottom line 2), but his relief-leverage résumé is thin and old — of 47 relief entries 2019-21, only 12 came in one-run-margin or tied states; most were mop-up shapes. Use him at left-handed stretches inside his bulk outings first; a defined late-inning role should wait for post-return evidence. (*Profile-driven, not H2H-driven — and it says so.*)
- Rest: no signal to plan around.** wOBA-against by rest before starts: 4 days .276 (37 GS), 5 days .303 (39), 6+ .343 (18). No measurable benefit to extra rest in the record — routine over rest.
- The Freeman clause.** The use case asked, so the receipt exists: 2024-10-25, World Series, 10th inning, first pitch, 92.2-mph four-seam — grand slam. Postseason context only. The serious version of the joke is bottom line 4: that pitch was thrown at 92; don't ask the 90-mph version of him for it.

Battery — pitch selection

- vs LHB: sweeper-first mentality, fastball as the change of eye level.** The sweeper (.247 xwOBAcon, 35.1% whiff) should be the identity pitch away; the four-seam at 51% usage is carrying .457 xwOBAcon and 7 HR — cut its share, and when it goes, go up, not middle-away at the belt.
- vs RHB: cutter-in, changeup-away, four-seam up.** The changeup is the two-strike putaway (32.7% whiff); keep it arm-side low (its lived location, +0.87 ft). Don't fall into the behind-in-the-count cutter tell (44.8% when behind).
- First pitch is the fix with the highest leverage.** Peak FPSR .672 → decline .607. His whole decline-era profile improves if pitch one lands; nothing about it requires velocity.

Pitching department — monitoring cues

1. **Velo band:** 2024 baseline 92.1 (Sept 92.7); 2025 pre-surgery 90.1. **Green ≥ 91.5 , yellow 90.5-91.5, red < 90.5** on the four-seam, measured over rolling 50-pitch windows in rehab/bulk outings.
2. **Shape check:** IVB ~ 19.3 in is his signature — any post-surgery reading below ~ 18.5 is a mechanical flag even if velo looks fine.
3. **Slot baseline:** arm angle has drifted $45^\circ \rightarrow 51^\circ$ over three years; capture his first post-surgery bullpens against `dp_uc36_mechanics_by_season.csv` and decide *on purpose* which slot is being rebuilt.
4. **In-game health proxy:** his bad-day signature is whiff/zone decay at near-normal velo. A 90+ radar reading is not, by itself, evidence he's right.
5. **Two developmental levers that don't need the arm:** first-pitch strike restoration (-6.5 pts from peak) and the four-seam-to-LHB usage cut (battery item 1).

Candid data-window & freshness caveats

- **2026 true gap:** no competitive pitches since 2025-09-03; surgery mid-Oct 2025, procedure not publicly specified and not guessed. This is a pre-return baseline, not a current-form read.
- **2025 = 8 G / 157 PA**, itself split MIL(2)/SD(6) around a four-month in-season gap. Directional everywhere it appears; PA printed.
- 2023 is a 12-start injury season; "2023-24 decline" carries 978 PA total and is the product's best decline evidence.
- Relief-leverage evidence is 2019-21 vintage under different rules and roles.
- ERA/IP/saves are not derivable in this repo for this pitcher (no `gms_AI`); the deployment story runs on appearance-grain KPIs instead.
- Locked-function hygiene: published zone rate is the strict (tracked-population) variant; every EV mean is BIP-only; xwOBAcon is BIP-only (O1/O2/O3 hardenings inherited).
- Postseason (D .283 wOBA/42 PA · L .457/11 · W .256/8) is context and never blends into rates.
- Receipts for every number: `out/dp_uc36_*.csv` (28 files) · figures 1-5 · DQ scorecard (29 checks, 0 FAIL, 1 WARN — a sample-size disclosure) · freshness manifest with all manual carry-ins.
- **Closure step:** re-run and grade this baseline at his first 100 Phillies batters faced (or after 3 rehab outings if a MiLB cache lands). The three falsifiable calls to grade: velocity band determines results; the lefty edge holds; first-pitch strike rate is the leading indicator of outing quality.